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G H A N A



Youth Perceptions of Public Sector Careers in Ghana:

An Analysis of Motivations and Deterrents

JANUARY 2025

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Emerging Public Leaders of Ghana (EPL Ghana) extends its sincere gratitude to its esteemed academic institutions, especially the University of Ghana, the University of Cape Coast and Kwame Nkrumah University of Science and Technology. The commitment to support this study was instrumental in facilitating a comprehensive survey on “Youth Perceptions of Public Sector Careers in Ghana: An Analysis of Motivations and Deterrents”. This collaborative effort has ensured the success and credibility of this study. EPL Ghana is grateful for the invaluable insights gleaned from the students of these academic institutions. The information provided will inform the development of policies, interventions, and best practices to enhance the work of the public sector in Ghana. The findings will advocate for youth engagement in Ghana’s Public Sector. EPL Ghana remains firmly committed to fostering sustainable growth, empowerment, and prosperity for the youth and the public sector in Ghana.

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INTRODUCTION



Youth unemployment and underemployment have become pressing concerns world-wide (ILO, 2024), particularly in developing countries like Ghana. The world has 1.2 billion young people, primarily in developing countries, with Africa projected to reach 830 million youth by 2050 (UNESCO, 2023). As this population grows, youth empowerment becomes crucial for achieving all Sustainable Development Goals, emphasising the importance of supporting young people in contributing a sustainable future. Ghana's youth population (15–35) is 38.3 percent out of a total population of 30,832,019 (GSS, 2021).

As the youth population continues to grow, the capacity of the public sector to absorb this age group becomes a significant issue for national development (IOE, 2024). Historically, the public sector has been seen as a stable and respectable employment avenue, offering job security, opportunities for career progression, and a platform to serve the country. However, in recent years, perceptions of public sector careers among young people have shifted, with many perceiving these roles as less appealing than careers in the private sector or entrepreneurship.

Despite the historical significance of the public sector in providing employment, several factors deter young people from pursuing these careers. These include perceived inefficiencies, low wages, limited career mobility, and concerns about corruption. Many young people view public sector jobs as a "last resort," characterised by stagnation and rigid bureaucracies. In a labour market that is becoming increasingly competitive, young Ghanaians are turning away from public sector opportunities in favour of what they see as more dynamic, innovative, and financially rewarding private sector jobs (Dadzie, Fumey & Namara, 2020). Furthermore, entrepreneurship has emerged as an attractive alternative, driven by a desire for autonomy and creative freedom, mostly lacking in the public sector. The problem is further exacerbated by societal, cultural, and educational factors influencing youth perceptions of public sector careers (Summera, & Yasmin, 2022). Educational systems often emphasise skills suited to the private sector, leading to a disconnect between graduates' training and public service needs. Societal attitudes and media reports also contribute to the notion that public sector work is less prestigious or impactful compared to private entrepreneurship or corporate roles.

This study, on "Youth Perceptions of Public Sector Careers: An Analysis of Motivations and Deterrents," explores the factors influencing young people's perceptions of the public sector. Specifically, it seeks to understand what attracts youth to public sector careers, the barriers that deter them, and how societal, cultural, and educational factors influence their perspectives. By addressing these concerns, this study will contribute to policy discussions on improving youth engagement in public-sector employment, ensuring that the sector remains attractive to young talent and capable of fulfilling its mandate in the country's development.

METHODOLOGY

2.1 INTRODUCTION

This study adopted a quantitative research approach to explore the perceptions of university students in Ghana regarding public sector careers. The primary objective is to understand the motivations and deterrents influencing their decisions to pursue employment in the public sector. A questionnaire was administered online for the survey. The study's focus on measurable variables, such as motivations, deterrents, and societal influences, makes the quantitative approach suitable for generating statistically significant results.

The study's target population consists of university students across Ghana, aged 18 to 32, who are expected to enter the labour market after completing their education or have joined the labour market. Students were sampled from all public and private universities across Ghana, ensuring a broad student body representation.

The study had 155 respondents. The sample was stratified by sex, with 57.8 percent male (88) and 43.2 percent female (67) respondents to ensure gender representation that reflects real-world dynamics in public sector employment. A simple random sampling technique was used to ensure that the sample reflects the proportional representation of students from various universities and programmes of study. This technique ensured geographical and institutional diversity, representing students from urban and rural universities and public and private institutions. The data was analysed descriptively.

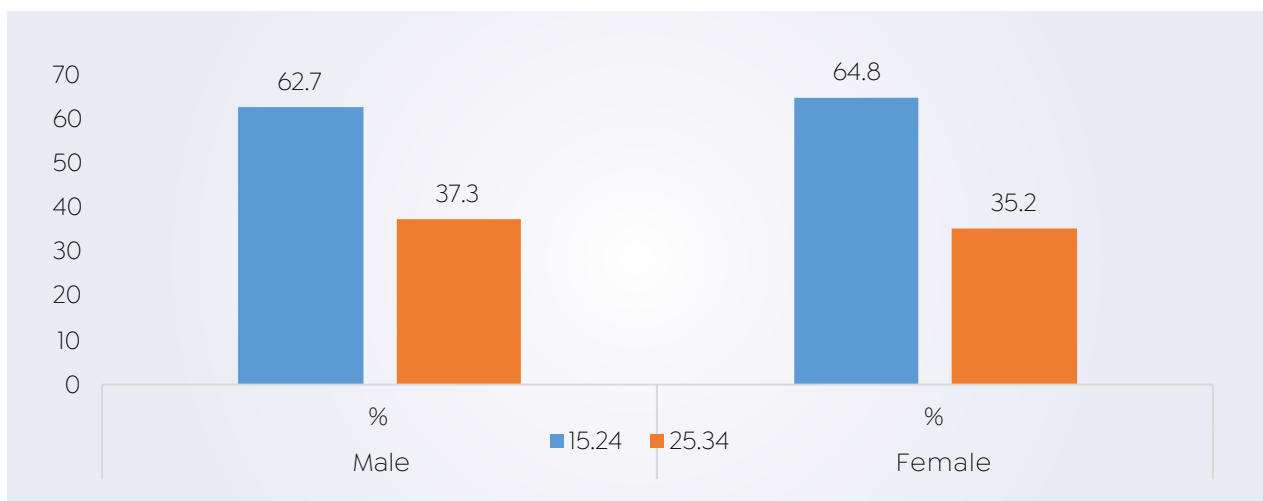


RESULTS AND FINDINGS

3.1 BACKGROUND CHARACTERISTICS OF THE YOUTH (18-32)

Figure 1 shows the age distribution of respondents by sex. The age distribution showed a higher proportion of youth in the 15-24 age group across both sexes (63.9%), with females comprising 62.7 percent and males 64.8 percent. A few of the youth were aged 25-34, (females 37.3% and males 35.2%).

Figure 1: Age Distribution of Youth by Sex (%)

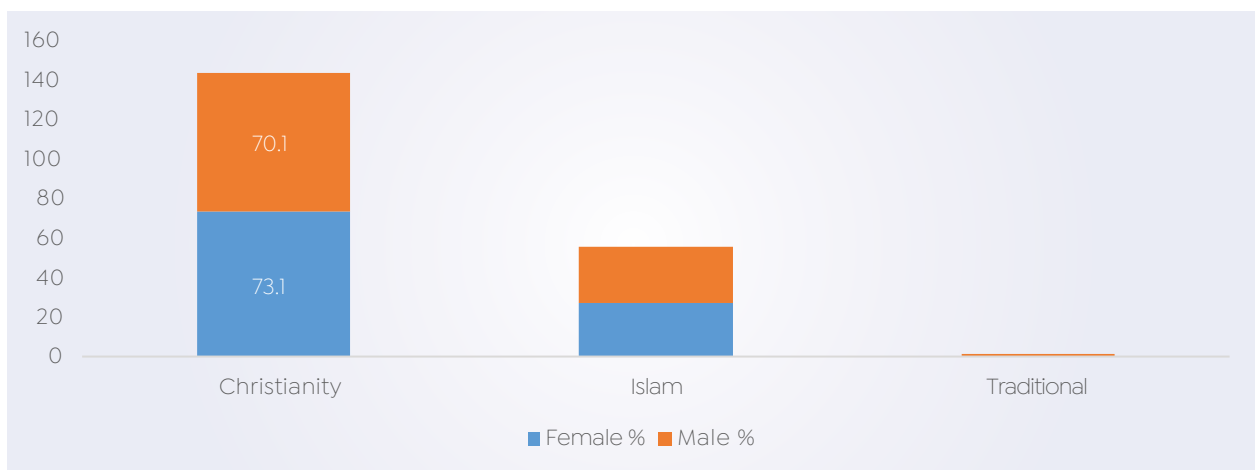


Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

Religious Affiliation

Figure 2 shows the religious distribution of the respondents by sex. Most (71.6%) of the youth were affiliated with Christianity. Christianity, the predominant religion among youth, accounted for 73.1 percent of females and 70.1 percent of males. Islam (27.7%) follows, with 26.9 percent for females and 28.4 percent for males. The least of the youth were affiliated with the traditional religion (0.6%).

Figure 2: Religious Affiliation of Youth by Sex (%)

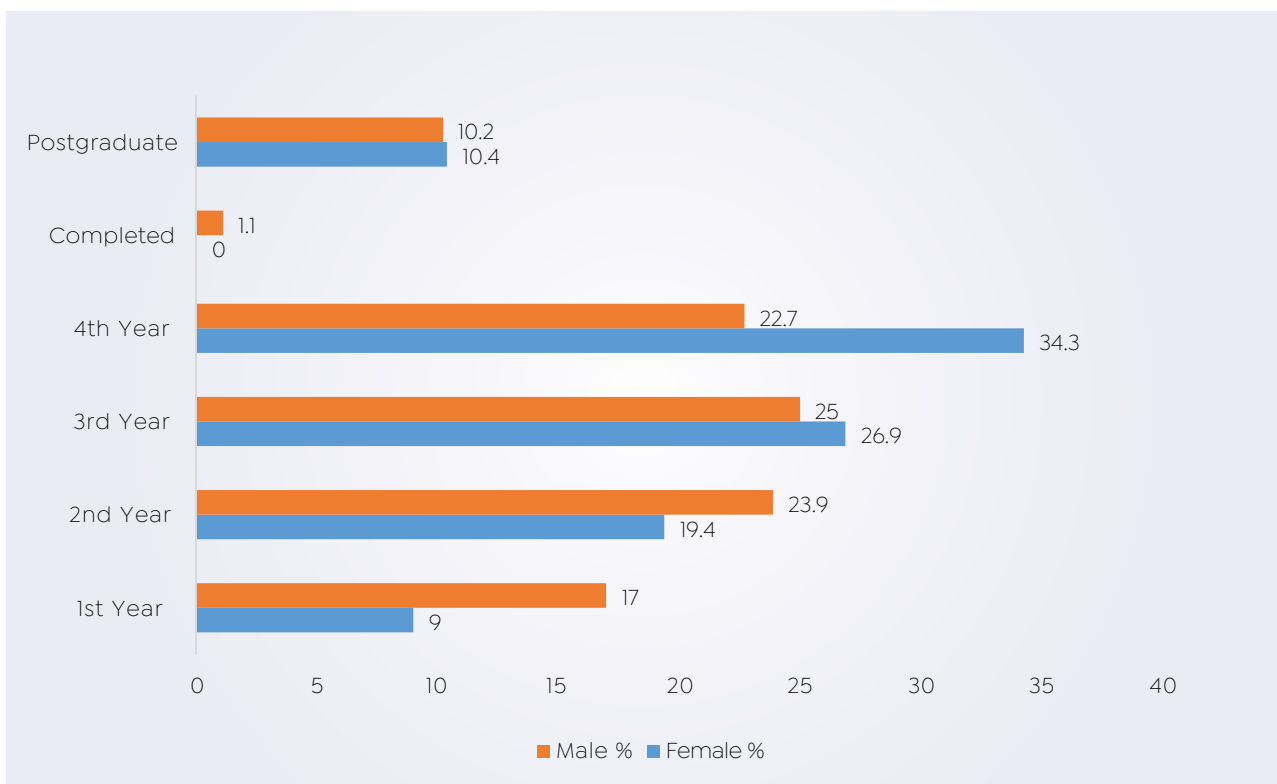


Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

Year of University of Youth

Figure 3 presents the university year of respondents by sex. Results indicate that most (27.7%) youth were in their 4th year of university, with 34.3 percent of females and 22.7 percent of males. Postgraduate students account for 10.3 percent, while only 0.6 per cent have completed university. First-year enrollment (13.5%) is higher among males (17.0%) than females (9.0%). The results indicate a balanced gender representation across university years, with male dominance in the early years and female dominance in the advanced years.

Figure 3 University Year of Youth by Sex (%)

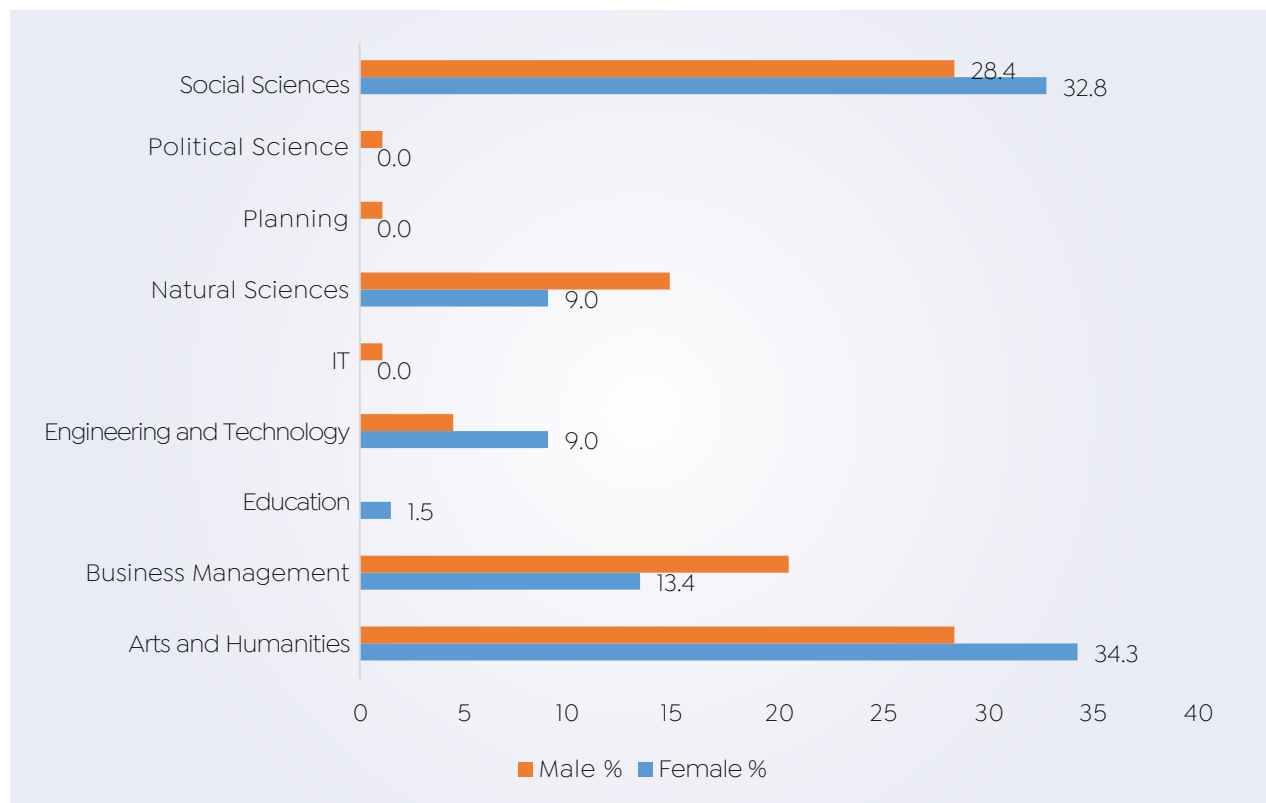


Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

Field of Study

Figure 4 describes the respondents' fields of study. The results show that the Arts and Humanities (31.0%) and Social Sciences (30.3%) were the most popular fields among respondents, with slightly higher representation for females. Business and management ranked third (17.4%) and is higher among males. Fields such as Education, IT, Planning, and Political Science show minimal interest, collectively under 3 percent.

Figure 4: Field of Study of Youth by Sex (%)

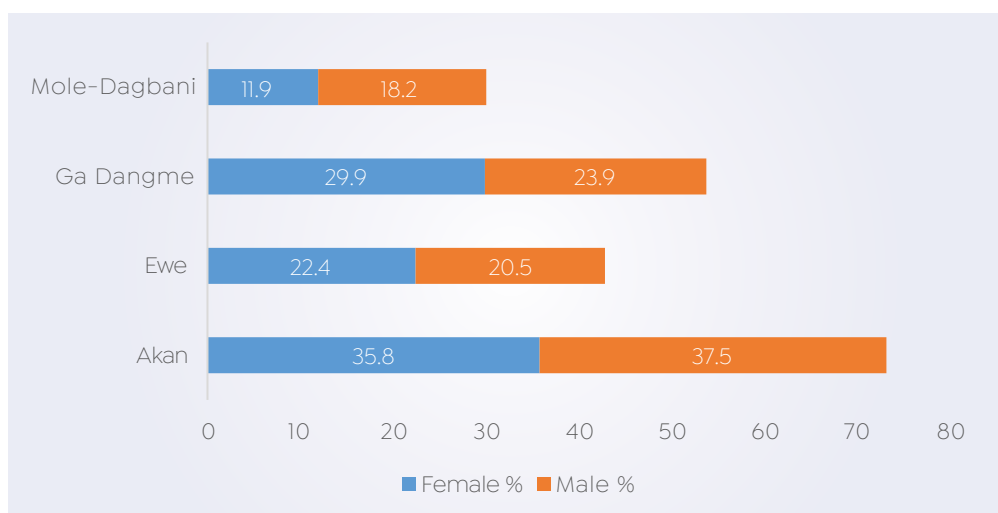


Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

Ethnicity

Table 5 indicates the ethnicity of respondents by sex. The results show that most (36.8%) respondents were Akans, with 35.8 percent being females and 37.5 percent representing males. Respondents who were Ewe constituted 21.3 percent, and Mole-Dagbani was 15.5 percent, with males showing a higher proportion (18.2%).

Figure 5: Ethnicity of Youth by Sex (%)



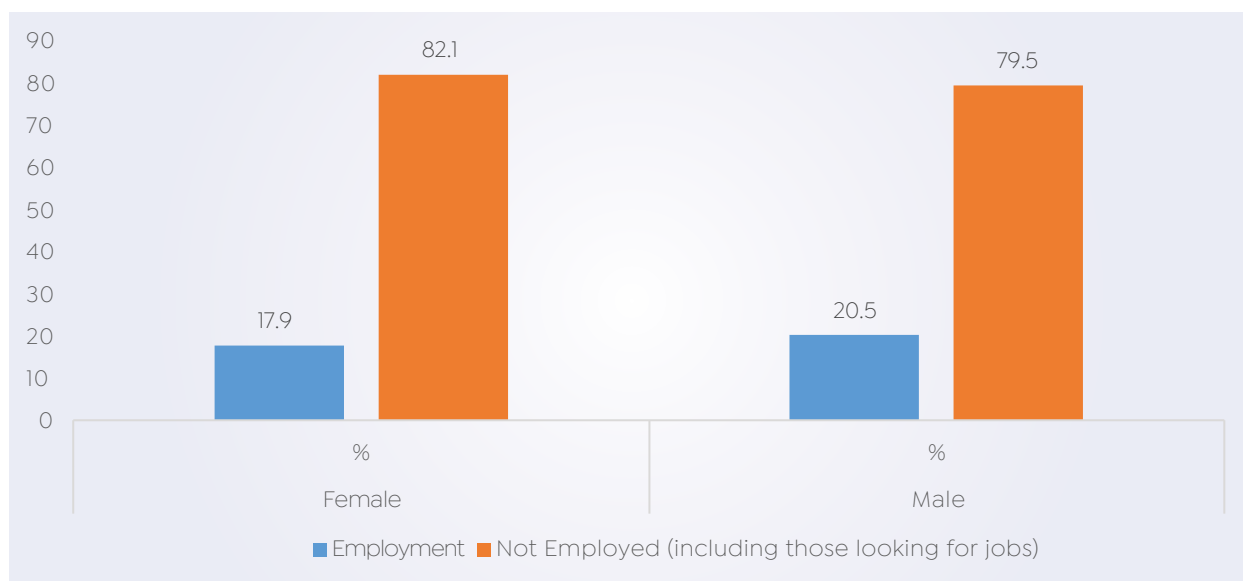
Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

Economic Activity and Sector of Employment

Figure 6 and 7 show respondents' economic activity and employment sector. The results highlight significant youth unemployment, with 80.6 percent unemployed, including job seekers (82.1% females, 79.5% males). Among the employed, males had a higher proportion of 20.5 percent compared to 17.9 percent of females.

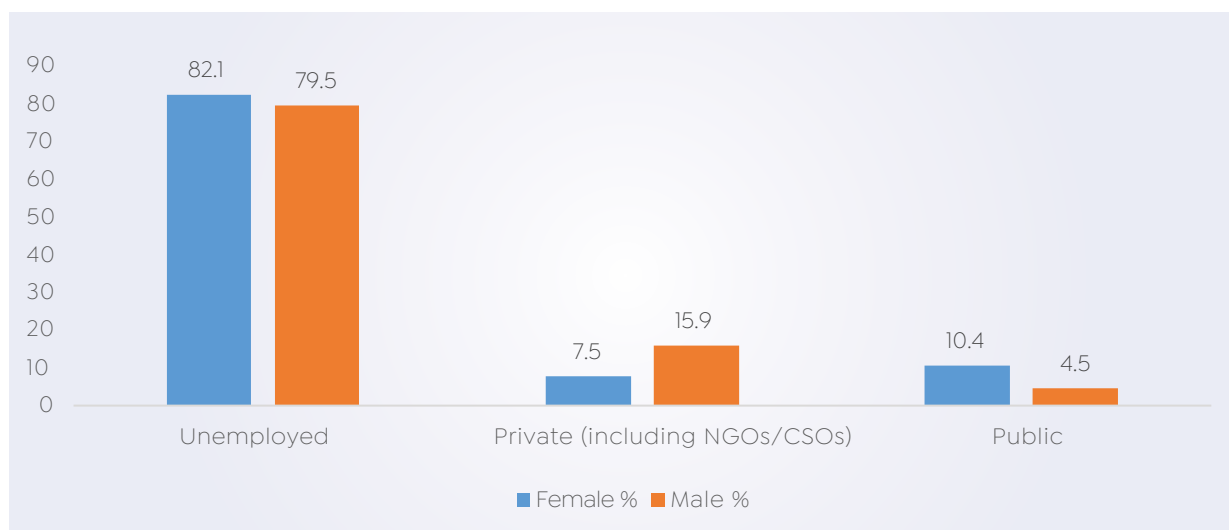
Employment is skewed towards the private sector (12.3%), where males outnumber females (15.9% vs. 7.5%). Public sector employment constituted 7.1 percent of respondents, with females having a higher proportion (10.4%) than males (4.5%).

Figure 6 Economic Activity of Youth by Sex (%)



Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

Figure 7: Sector of Employment by Sex (%)

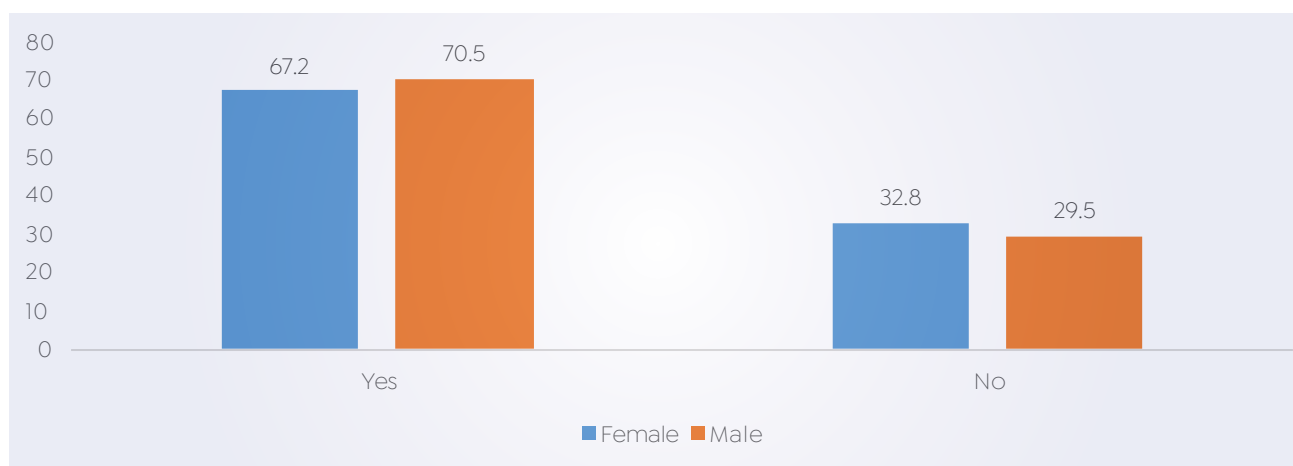


Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

Family Members Working in the Public Sector

Figure 8 describes respondents who have family members in the public sector. The results showed that 69.0 percent of youth had family members in the public sector, with slightly more males (70.5%) than females (67.2%). This suggests a significant familial presence in the public sector, which could influence youth perspectives on career opportunities and familiarity with public service roles.

Figure 8 Family Members of Youth Working in the Public Sector by Sex (%)

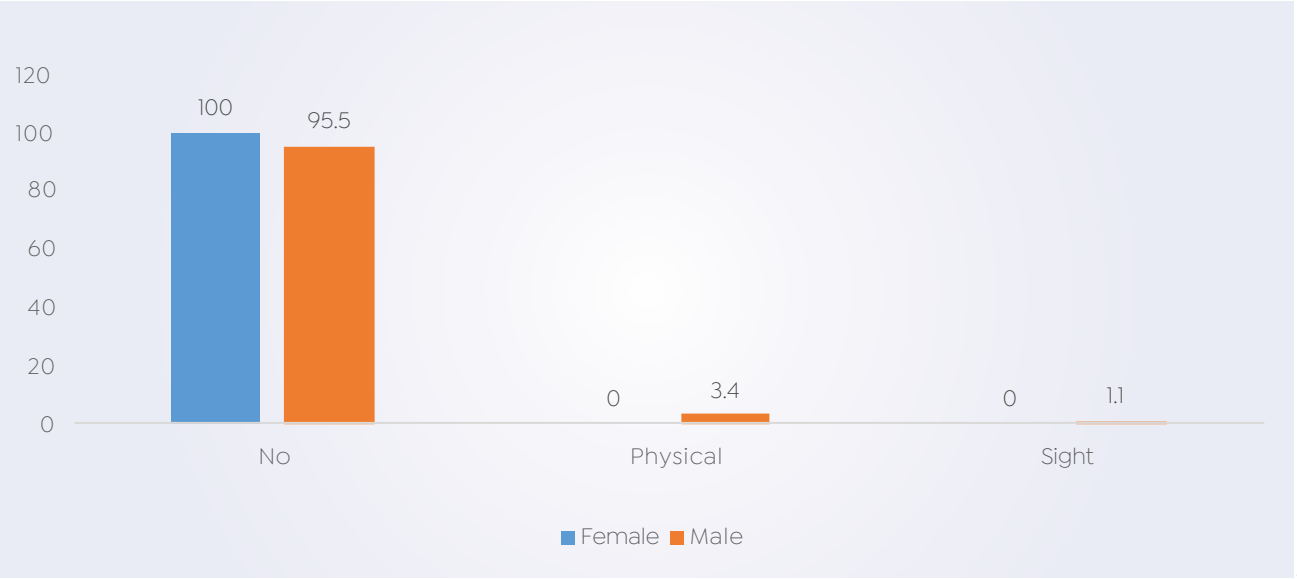


Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

Disability by Sex

Figure 9 shows respondents with disabilities by sex. The data indicates that 97.4 percent of youth reported no disability (females 100% and males 95.5%). Physical disabilities indicated 1.9 percent among males, while sight impairment represented 0.6 percent.

Figure 9: Youth Disability by Sex (%)



Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

FACTORS THAT INFLUENCE THE YOUTH PERCEPTION OF PUBLIC CAREER

4.1 KNOWLEDGE AND YOUTH PERCEPTION OF PUBLIC SECTOR CAREERS

Knowledge of the Public Sector and Youth Perception of the Public Sector Career

Table 1 shows the youth's knowledge of the public sector and their perception of the public sector career. A proportion of 58.1 percent of the youth with low levels of knowledge perceived the public sector negatively, while 33.5 percent with moderate knowledge had a similar perception. Only 8.4 percent with high knowledge viewed it positively.

Among females, 46.3 percent with low knowledge, 43.3 percent with moderate knowledge, and 10.4 percent with high knowledge perceived the public sector negatively. A slightly higher proportion of females with high knowledge (33.3%) had a favourable view compared to others.

For males, 67 percent with low knowledge perceived the sector negatively, and 26.1 percent with moderate knowledge shared this view. Only 6.8 percent with high knowledge perceived it positively, indicating a generally negative trend.

NB: Some variables in the tables may have rounding adjustments, causing the total percentage to slightly differ from 100%

Table 1: Knowledge of the Public Sector by Sex and Youth Perception of the Public Sector Career

Sex	Level of Knowledge	Perception of the Public Sector			P value=0.003
		Low	Moderate	High	
		%	%	%	%
Female	Low	46.7	51.1	22.2	46.3
	Moderate	40.0	44.2	44.4	43.3
	High	13.3	4.7	33.3	10.4
Male	Low	88.0	58.0	61.5	67.0
	Moderate	12.0	36.0	15.4	26.1
	High	0.0	6.0	23.1	6.8
Total	Low	29 (72.5)	51 (54.8)	10 (45.5)	90 (58.1)
	Moderate	9 (22.5)	37 (39.8)	6 (27.3)	52 (33.5)
	High	2 (5.0)	5 (5.4)	6 (27.3)	13 (8.4)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

Source of Information about Public Sector Job Opportunities and Youth Perception of Public Sector Careers

Table 2 presents information about public sector job opportunities and youth perception of public sector careers. Generally, online job portals emerged as the primary source of information about the public sector for youth, with 43.2 percent of respondents using them, followed by social media (20.6%) and family/friends (21.3%). There were significant differences between females and males. For females, online job portals (47.8%) were the most common source, while males primarily relied on them (39.8%). Social media had a more significant influence on males (25%) than females (14.9%). Public sector recruitment drives were less common across both groups, with only 16.4 percent of females and 8 percent of males citing them as a source of information.

Table 2: Source of Information about Public Sector Job Opportunities by Sex and Youth Perception of Public Sector Careers

Sex	Source of Information about the Public Sector	Perception of Public Sector Career			P value=0.452
		Low	Moderate	High	Total
		%	%	No. %	%
Female	Family and Friends	13.3	25.6	11.1	20.9
	Online Job Portals	60.0	46.5	33.3	47.8
	Public Sector Recruitment Drives	26.7	14.0	11.1	16.4
	Social Media	0.0	14.0	44.4	14.9
Male	Family and Friends	20.0	20.0	30.8	21.6
	I Barely See Them	0.0	2.0	0.0	1.1
	Online Job Portals	48.0	40.0	23.1	39.8
	Public Sector Recruitment Drives	4.0	12.0	0.0	8.0
	Social Media	24.0	22.0	38.5	25.0
	University Career Services	4.0	4.0	7.7	4.5
Total	Family and Friends	7 (17.5)	21 (22.6)	5 (22.7)	33 (21.3)
	I Barely See Them	0 (0.0)	1 (1.1)	0 (0.0)	1 (0.6)
	Online Job Portals	21 (52.5)	40 (43.0)	6 (27.3)	67 (43.2)
	Public Sector Recruitment Drives	5 (12.5)	12 (12.9)	1 (4.5)	18 (11.6)
	Social Media	6 (15.0)	17 (18.3)	9 (40.9)	32 (20.6)
	University Career Services	1 (2.5)	2 (2.2)	1 (4.5)	4 (2.6)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

4.2 ATTITUDE AND YOUTH PERCEPTION OF PUBLIC SECTOR CAREERS

Attraction to the Public Sector and Perception of Public Sector Career

Table 3 presents youth attraction to the public sector and the perception of public sector careers. The variable "level of attraction" is a composite variable showing the importance of factors (job stability, career advancement opportunities, public service motivation (desire to serve the public), job security and work-life balance) attracting the youth to the public sector career. Table 10 shows significant variation in youth attraction to public sector careers. The majority of the youth (56.1%) had a low attraction, with females (59.7%) having a slightly higher proportion than males (53.4%). Moderate attraction constituted 28.4 percent higher among males (33.0%) than females (22.4%).

High attraction is the least at 15.5 percent, though more pronounced among females (17.9%) than males (13.6%). Few of the youth were highly attracted to public sector careers, which correlates strongly with positive perceptions of public sector careers, as seen in 45.5 percent of highly attracted youth. The significant p-value (0.000) indicates strong associations between perception and attraction, emphasising the role of job stability, career advancement opportunities, public service motivation (desire to serve the public), job security and work-life balance.

Table 3 Attraction towards the Public Sector (PS) by Sex and Youth Perception of Public Sector Career

Sex	Level of Attraction towards the Public Sector	Perception of Public Sector Career			P value=0.000
		Low	Moderate	High	
		%	%	%	%
Female	Low	86.7	58.1	22.2	59.7
	Moderate	6.7	27.9	22.2	22.4
	High	6.7	14.0	55.6	17.9
Male	Low	72.0	52.0	23.1	53.4
	Moderate	20.0	38.0	38.5	33.0
	High	8.0	10.0	38.5	13.6
Total	Low	31 (77.5)	51 (54.8)	5 (22.7)	87 (56.1)
	Moderate	6 (15.0)	31 (33.3)	7 (31.8)	44 (28.4)
	High	3 (7.5)	11 (11.8)	10 (45.5)	24 (15.5)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

Decision to Choose Public Sector and Youth Perception of the Public Sector Career

Table 4 presents factors that influence the decision of the youth to choose the Public Sector and their Perception of Public Sector Careers. The result shows that job stability (40.6%) and public service motivation (29.7%) were the most influential factors for youth choosing public sector careers, with females emphasising public service motivation (37.3%) and males prioritising job stability (43.2%). Career advancement opportunities are moderately influential (18.1%), particularly for males with high perceptions (46.2%). Work-life balance (11.0%) and job security (0.6%) had limited influence.

Gender differences are evident, with males valuing stability and advancement opportunities more, while females focus on motivation and work-life balance.

Table 4: Influence on Decision to Choose Public Sector by Sex and Youth Perception of Public Sector Career

Sex	Influence on Decision to Choose Public Sector	Perception of Public Sector Career			P value=0.402
		Low	Moderate	High	
		%	%	%	%
Female	Career Advancement Opportunities	20.0	16.3	0.0	14.9
	Job Security	6.7	0.0	0.0	1.5
	Job Stability	20.0	46.5	22.2	37.3
	Public Service Motivation	46.7	27.9	66.7	37.3
	Work-Life Balance	6.7	9.3	11.1	9.0
Male	Career Advancement Opportunities	16.0	16.0	46.2	20.5
	Job Stability	48.0	44.0	30.8	43.2
	Public Service Motivation	24.0	24.0	23.1	23.9
	Work-Life Balance	12.0	16.0	0.0	12.5
Total	Career Advancement Opportunities	7 (17.5)	15 (16.1)	6 (27.3)	28 (18.1)
	Job Security	1 (2.5)	0 (0.0)	0 (0.0)	1 (0.6)
	Job Stability	15 (37.5)	42 (45.2)	6 (27.3)	63 (40.6)
	Public Service Motivation	13 (32.5)	24 (25.8)	9 (40.9)	46 (29.7)
	Work-Life Balance	4 (10.0)	12 (12.9)	1 (4.5)	17 (11.0)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

Long-Term Benefits of Public Sector Careers and Youth Perception of Public Sector Career

Table 5 shows the perceived long-term benefits of public sector careers and youth perception of public sector careers. A majority of youth (45.2%) perceived the private sector as offering more significant long-term benefits, followed by the public sector (32.3%) and an equal balance (18.7%). Only a few of the youth (3.9%) were unsure.

Among females, 50.7 percent perceived private sector benefits as more advantageous, while 28.4 percent favoured public sector benefits. Also, 19.4 percent of females perceived equal benefits, and only 1.5 percent were unsure. For males, 40.9 percent believed the private sector offers more significant benefits, 35.2 percent favour the public sector, and 18.2 percent perceive equal benefits. A slightly higher proportion of males (5.7%) were unsure compared to females. Gender differences are evident.

Table 5: Perceived Long-Term Benefits of Public Sector Careers by Sex and Youth Perception of Public Sector Career

Sex	Perceived Long-Term Benefits	Perception of Public Sector Career			P value=0.001
		Low	Moderate	High	
		%	%	%	%
Female	Equally beneficial	33.3	9.3	44.4	19.4
	More beneficial in the private sector	26.7	60.5	44.4	50.7
	More beneficial in the public sector	33.3	30.2	11.1	28.4
	Unsure	6.7	0.0	0.0	1.5
Male	Equally beneficial	32.0	6.0	38.5	18.2
	More beneficial in the private sector	32.0	48.0	30.8	40.9
	More beneficial in the public sector	32.0	40.0	23.1	35.2
	Unsure	4.0	6.0	7.7	5.7
Total	Equally beneficial	13 (32.5)	7 (7.5)	9 (40.9)	29 (18.7)
	More beneficial in the private sector	12 (30.0)	50 (53.8)	8 (36.4)	70 (45.2)
	More beneficial in the public sector	13 (32.5)	33 (35.5)	4 (18.2)	50 (32.3)
	Unsure	2 (5.0)	3 (3.2)	1 (4.5)	6 (3.9)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

Importance of Social Impact of Youth Decision to Pursue a Public Sector Career and Perception of Public Sector Career

Table 6 shows the importance of the social impact of youth decisions and perceptions of public sector careers. Most youth (52.3%) perceived the importance of social impact in public sector careers as low, while, 27.1 percent rate it as moderate, and 20.6 percent perceived it as high.

Among males, 53.4 percent considered social impact low, compared to 50.7 percent of females. However, more females (23.9%) rate is higher than males (18.2%). Interestingly, males showed a stronger inclination toward moderate importance (28.4%) than females (25.4%). Females value social impact more when youth perceptions are positive, while males display a broader distribution across categories, suggesting slightly differing motivations regarding public sector social impact.

Table 6: Importance of making Social Impact on the Decision to pursue a Public Sector Career by Sex and Youth Perception of Public Sector Career

Sex	Importance of Social Impact	Perception of Public Sector Career			P value=0.137
		Low	Moderate	High	
		%	%	%	%
Female	Low	60.0	46.5	55.6	50.7
	Moderate	26.7	30.2	0.0	25.4
	High	13.3	23.3	44.4	23.9
Male	Low	56.0	64.0	7.7	53.4
	Moderate	24.0	22.0	61.5	28.4
	High	20.0	14.0	30.8	18.2
Total	Low	23 (57.5)	52 (55.9)	6 (27.3)	81 (52.3)
	Moderate	10 (25.0)	24 (25.8)	8 (36.4)	42 (27.1)
	High	7 (17.5)	17 (18.3)	8 (36.4)	32 (20.6)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

Influence of Mentorship/Guidance from Public Sector Professionals on Youth Decision to Pursue a Career in the Public Service and Perception of Public Sector Career

Table 7 shows the influence of mentorship/guidance from public sector professionals on youth's decision to pursue a career in public service and their perception of a public sector career. Almost 53 percent (52.9%) of youth perceived mentorship/guidance as influencing their perception of public sector careers, 23.9 percent did not find it impactful, and 23.2 percent were uncertain.

Among males, 51.1 percent viewed mentorship positively, 25 percent were unsure, and 23.9 percent did not perceived it as influential. Females exhibit a stronger inclination toward the influence of mentorship, with 55.2 percent acknowledging its role compared to 51.1 percent of males. Only 23.9 percent of females found it unimportant, and 20.9 percent were not sure, indicating a slightly higher appreciation for mentorship's impact among females than males.

Table 7 Influence of Mentorship/Guidance from Public Sector Professionals on Decision to Pursue a Career in the Public Service by Sex and Youth Perception of Public Sector Career

Sex	Influence of Mentorship/ Guidance	Perception of Public Sector Career			Pval- ue=0.995
		Low	Moderate	High	
		%	%	%	%
Female	No	26.7	20.9	33.3	23.9
	Yes	53.3	53.5	66.7	55.2
	Maybe	20.0	25.6	0.0	20.9
Male	No	24.0	26.0	15.4	23.9
	Yes	48.0	54.0	46.2	51.1
	Maybe	28.0	20.0	38.5	25.0
Total	No	10 (25.0)	22 (23.7)	5 (22.7)	37 (23.9)
	Yes	20 (50.0)	50 (53.8)	12 (54.5)	82 (52.9)
	Maybe	10 (25.0)	21 (22.6)	5 (22.7)	36 (23.2)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

p<0.05

Deterrents Discouraging Youth from Pursuing Public Sector Employment

Table 8 shows factors deterring the youth from entering the public sector and their perceptions of public sector careers. The variable "level of deterrence" is a composite variable showing the importance of factors (Job stability, career advancement opportunities, public service motivation (desire to serve the public), job security, and work-life balance) deterring the youth from the public sector career. Most youth (56.8%) experienced low deterrence from public sector careers, while 35.5 percent reported moderate deterrence and 7.7 percent faced high deterrence. The results from Table 8 show a significant difference in perceptions based on levels of deterrence.

Among females, 56.7 percent reported low deterrence, 32.8 percent moderate, and 10.4% high deterrence. This indicates that while most females see fewer barriers, a few perceive considerable deterrence. For males, 56.8 percent reported low deterrence, however, 37.5 percent of males experience moderate deterrence, and only 5.7 percent reported high deterrence, reflecting slightly less concern than females.

Table 8 Level of Deterrent to the Public Sector (PS) by Sex and Youth Perception of Public Sector Career

Sex	Level of Deterrence	Perception of Public Sector Career			P value= 0.000
		Low	Moderate	High	
		%	%	%	%
Female	Low	73.3	53.5	44.4	56.7
	Moderate	20.0	39.5	22.2	32.8
	High	6.7	7.0	33.3	10.4
Male	Low	88.0	50.0	23.1	56.8
	Moderate	12.0	44.0	61.5	37.5
	High	0.0	6.0	15.4	5.7
Total	Low	33 (82.5)	48 (51.6)	7 (31.8)	88 (56.8)
	Moderate	6 (15.0)	39 (41.9)	10 (45.5)	55 (35.5)
	High	1 (2.5)	6 (6.5)	5 (22.7)	12 (7.7)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

Lack of career progression opportunities in the public sector and Youth Perception of Public Sector Career

Table 9 indicates the perceived lack of career progression opportunities in the public sector and the perception of public sector careers. 42.6 percent of youth perceived a lack of career progression opportunities as a significant factor influencing their perception of public sector careers. Those unsure about this factor account for 26.5 percent, while 31 percent do not consider it influential.

Among females, 43.3 percent believed a lack of career progression opportunities affects their perception of public sector careers. Meanwhile, 32.8 percent were unsure, and 23.9 percent feel it is not a deterrent, showing a balanced distribution of perspectives. For males, 42 percent perceived lack of career progression as influential, but a more significant proportion (36.4%) disagreed, and 21.6 percent were unsure. This indicates that males were slightly less deterred than females.

Table 9 Lack of Career Progression Opportunities in the Public Sector by Sex and Youth Perception of Public Sector Career

Sex	Lack of Career Progression Opportunities	Perception of Public Sector Career			P value-0.576
		Low	Moderate	High	
		%	%	%	%
Female	Yes	60.0	39.5	33.3	43.3
	No	13.3	23.3	44.4	23.9
	Not sure	26.7	37.2	22.2	32.8
Male	Yes	36.0	46.0	38.5	42.0
	No	48.0	30.0	38.5	36.4
	Not sure	16.0	24.0	23.1	21.6
Total	Yes	18 (45.0)	40 (43.0)	8 (36.4)	66 (42.6)
	No	14 (35.0)	25 (26.9)	9 (40.9)	48 (31.0)
	Not sure	8 (20.0)	28 (30.1)	5 (22.7)	41 (26.5)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

Influence of Perceived Bureaucracy in the Public Sector Career Choice and Youth Perception in the Public Sector

Table 10 shows the influence of perceived bureaucracy on career choice and youth perception in the public sector. Approximately 49 percent of youth reported being somewhat discouraged by perceived bureaucracy in the public sector, 23.2 percent were significantly discouraged, and 21.9 percent felt it had no influence. Only 5.8 percent viewed it as motivation to seek change within the system.

Among females, 47.8 percent were somewhat discouraged, and 23.9 percent felt discouraged. Also, 20.9 percent stated that bureaucracy had no influence, and 7.5 percent saw it as a motivation to enact change. For males, 50 percent were somewhat discouraged, 22.7 percent were significantly discouraged, and 22.7 percent reported no influence. However, 4.5 percent found it is encouraging to seek systemic change, slightly lower than for females.

Table 10 Influence of Perceived Bureaucracy in the Public Sector career choice by Sex and Perception of Youth in the Public Sector

Sex	Influence of perceived bureaucracy in the public sector	Perception of the Public Sector			P value=0.001
		Low	Moderate	High	
		%	%	%	%
Female	It encourages me to seek change within the system	0.0	11.6	0.0	7.5
	It has no influence	6.7	16.3	66.7	20.9
	It significantly discourages me	33.3	23.3	11.1	23.9
	It somewhat discourages me	60.0	48.8	22.2	47.8
Male	It encourages me to seek change within the system	0.0	2.0	23.1	4.5
	It has no influence	24.0	18.0	38.5	22.7
	It significantly discourages me	8.0	30.0	23.1	22.7
	It somewhat discourages me	68.0	50.0	15.4	50.0

Sex	Influence of perceived bureaucracy in the public sector	Perception of the Public Sector			P value=0.001
		Low	Moderate	High	Total
Total	It encourages me to seek change within the system	0 (0.0)	6 (6.5)	3 (13.6)	9 (5.8)
	It has no influence	7 (17.5)	16 (17.2)	11 (50.0)	34 (21.9)
	It significantly discourages me	7 (17.5)	25 (26.9)	4 (18.2)	36 (23.2)
	It somewhat discourages me	26 (65.0)	46 (49.5)	4 (18.2)	76 (49.0)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

4.3 SOCIO-CULTURAL FACTORS AND YOUTH PERCEPTION OF THE OF PUBLIC SECTOR CAREERS

Influence of Socio-Cultural Factors on Youth Perception of Public Sector Careers

Table 11 shows societal and cultural influences on youth perception of the public sector. Socio-cultural factors significantly influenced youth perceptions of public sector careers, with 48.4 percent of youth reporting low proportions of perceptions due to these. Also, 42.6 percent had moderate perceptions, and only 9 percent of youth had high perceptions.

Females with low and moderate perceptions (52.2% and 40.3%, respectively) felt the influence of socio-cultural factors. Among males, 45.5 percent with low perceptions and 44.3% with moderate perceptions were similarly impacted by socio-cultural factors. Few females (7.5%) and males (10.2%) with high perceptions were influenced by socio-cultural factors, suggesting a negative influence on overall public sector perceptions.

Table 11 Influence of Perceived Bureaucracy in the Public Sector Career Choice by Sex and Perception of Youth in the Public Sector

Sex	Influence of Socio-Cultural Factors	Perception in the Public Sector			P value=0.000
		Low	Moderate	High	
		%	%	%	%
Female	Low	60.0	53.5	33.3	52.2
	Moderate	40.0	44.2	22.2	40.3
	High	0.0	2.3	44.4	7.5
Male	Low	72.0	40.0	15.4	45.5
	Moderate	20.0	52.0	61.5	44.3
	High	8.0	8.0	23.1	10.2
Total	Low	27 (67.5)	43 (46.2)	5 (22.7)	75 (48.4)
	Moderate	11 (27.5)	45 (48.4)	10 (45.5)	66 (42.6)
	High	2 (5.0)	5 (5.4)	7 (31.8)	14 (9.0)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

Education Preparedness of Youth for a Career in the Public Sector

Table 12 shows the educational preparedness of youth for a career in the public sector. The analysis of youth perception regarding education preparedness for a public sector career shows differing views based on gender. Overall, 36.8 percent of youth reported that their education has prepared them well, while 30.3 percent felt unprepared, and 32.9 percent were unsure.

Among females, a significant percentage (60%) are unsure about their education preparedness, with 23.9 percent reporting unpreparedness and 29.9 percent reporting preparedness. Males, however, show a more favourable perception, with 48 percent feeling prepared, 28 percent unsure, and 35.2 percent not feeling prepared. The results suggest a general uncertainty among females and males regarding education readiness for public sector careers; however, education preparedness is significantly associated with youth perceptions of public sector careers.

Table 12 Influence of Perceived Bureaucracy in the Public Sector Career Choice by Sex and Perception of Youth in the Public Sector

Sex	Education Preparedness for a Career in the Public Sector	Perception of Public Sector Career			P value=0.038
		Low	Moderate	High	
Female		%	%	%	%
	Yes	33.3%	27.9%	33.3%	29.9%
	No	6.7%	27.9%	33.3%	23.9%
	Not sure	60.0%	44.2%	33.3%	46.3%
Male	Yes	48.0%	38.0%	46.2%	42.0%
	No	28.0%	40.0%	30.8%	35.2%
	Not sure	24.0%	22.0%	23.1%	22.7%
Total	Yes	17 (42.5%)	31 (33.3%)	9 (40.9%)	57 (36.8%)
	No	8 (20.0%)	32 (34.4%)	7 (31.8%)	47 (30.3%)
	Not sure	15 (37.5%)	30 (32.3%)	6 (27.3%)	51 (32.9%)

Source: EPL Ghana Survey, 2024

$p < 0.05$

DISCUSSION

The study on youth perceptions of public sector careers provides significant insights into the factors influencing youth public service career choices. Understanding these perceptions is critical in addressing the challenges of attracting and retaining talented youths in the public sector, which is essential for sustainable development and effective governance.

The growing interest among youth in pursuing careers within the public sector can be attributed to several key factors that have increasingly influenced their professional aspirations. One of the primary drivers is the perceived job security and stability associated with public-sector employment (Korac, Saliterer & Weigand, 2018). Young people often view public sector jobs as offering a reliable source of income and long-term employment, particularly in contexts where private sector opportunities are more volatile. Also, the social impact of public service serves as a compelling factor, as youth passionate about contributing to societal well-being see public sector careers as a platform to drive meaningful change (Neumann & Schott, 2021), especially in areas such as education, healthcare, and infrastructure development. Additionally, access to training and career development opportunities within the public sector is a significant attraction for the younger generation (Acheampong, 2020). When public sector organisations demonstrate transparent systems for professional growth and skill enhancement, it becomes a strong incentive for youth to consider these career paths (Linos, 2017).

Furthermore, the comprehensive benefits package offered by the public sector, including pensions, healthcare, and housing, is an attractive incentive for the youths seeking a stable and secure future (Acheampong, 2020). The combination of job security, social impact, professional development, and attractive benefits has emerged as a potent force driving youth interest and enthusiasm towards public sector careers.

Several deterrents dissuade the youth from pursuing public-sector employment. A

significant concern is the perception of bureaucratic inefficiency and corruption, which undermines the appeal of working in the sector (Mugellini, Della, Colagrossi, Isenring, & Killias, 2021). The youth are increasingly drawn to environments that value innovation, transparency, and efficiency attributes they often associate with private sector organisations or entrepreneurship (Wirtz, Kubin & Weyerer, 2021). Additionally, limited career advancement opportunities in the public sector, exacerbated by rigid hierarchies and inadequate merit-based promotions, discourage aspiring professionals (Norbert, 2024).

The study highlights the role of low remuneration as a critical deterrent, especially when public sector salaries are perceived to lag behind those in the private sector for equivalent roles (Makridis, 2021; Morrissey & Sherer, 2024). Furthermore, societal and cultural attitudes and stigmatisation can play a role, as some youth view public sector work as less prestigious or innovative than private sector jobs (Akosah-Twumasi, Emeto, Daniel, Tsey, & Malau-Aduli, 2018). Families and communities may prioritise certain professions in many contexts, shaping career aspirations from a young age (Barsoum, 2016; Ritz, Adrian & Brewer Gene, 2013). Education prioritising entrepreneurship or professions in emerging industries like technology may also steer young people away from public service (Ahmad, Muh & Idrus, Muhammad & Rijal, Syamsu, 2023; Gazi et al., 2024). Further, the study indicated that most youth have limited awareness of public sector opportunities (Kavaarpuo, Porekuu, & Yeboah, 2023; World Bank, 2022). This knowledge gap is often due to inadequate career guidance in educational institutions and government entities' lack of targeted outreach (Upoalkpajor, 2020).

CONCLUSION

Studying youth perceptions of public sector careers emphasises the complexity of attracting and retaining young talent in this critical sector. Motivational factors, such as job security, opportunities for social impact, and career development, highlight the potential appeal of public service. However, significant deterrents, including perceptions of inefficiency, corruption, limited career growth, and low remuneration, challenge the sector's ability to attract aspiring professionals.

The findings show that most youth have limited knowledge of public sector opportunities, a gap rooted in insufficient career guidance and outreach. Additionally, societal attitudes and cultural influences significantly influence career aspirations, often steering youth away from public service. These dynamics emphasise the importance of addressing both structural and perceptual barriers.

Understanding the motivations and deterrents influencing youth perceptions of public sector careers offers actionable insights for addressing talent shortages in this critical sector. Tailored strategies focusing on awareness, systemic reforms, and enhanced engagement are necessary to align public sector opportunities with the aspirations of the youth. By addressing these challenges holistically, the public sector can position itself as a viable and attractive career path for the next generation, ensuring sustainable and effective governance.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Addressing these issues requires systemic interventions.

01

Governments and public sector organisations must adopt targeted marketing and communication strategies to reform public perceptions.

02

Highlighting success stories, emphasising career growth opportunities, and showcasing the tangible societal impacts of public service can help attract young talent.

03

Implementing structural reforms, such as merit-based promotions and competitive salaries, is equally important to enhance the sector's appeal.

Strengthening partnerships with educational institutions to integrate public service awareness into curricula and offering internships can build a pipeline of motivated, informed youth ready to enter public service.

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